

At the First International Conference on Human Rights in Tehran in 1968, some countries questioned whether the idea of human rights was inapplicable to societies in Africa, Asia, and the Middle East. At 1993's Second World Conference on Human Rights in Vienna, the conference's declaration and program of action cautioned that "the significance of national and regional particularities and diverse historical, cultural, and religious backgrounds must be borne in mind" when promoting and protecting human rights.

This has led to concerns that relativism could undermine human rights by allowing countries to claim that their own traditions supersede all human rights claims. Some scholars, such as Abdullahi Ahmed An-Na'im, a Sudanese-American expert on Islamic law and human rights, have identified how rights such as the prohibition on torture have their origins in many different cultural and religious traditions around the world and argue it is wrong to dismiss human rights as simply a Western idea.

The UDHR was the starting point for many other human rights instruments that applied and extended the principles contained in the Declaration. In 1976, for example, the UN Commission on Human Rights set about drafting a treaty on women's rights, which became the 1979 Convention on the Elimination of all forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW). The preamble to this Convention noted that "the Universal Declaration of Human Rights affirms the principle of the inadmissibility of discrimination against women," but went on to note that despite this, "extensive discrimination against women continues to exist." This was an acknowledgment that the UDHR needed to be set within a new legal framework to deal with the complex nature of discrimination against women.

Similarly, in 1989, the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC) noted that the UDHR had proclaimed that children were entitled to "special care and

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Let us remember our roots as one human family, forever dedicated to upholding the central tenets of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights.

Barack Obama

44th US president (2009–2017)

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assistance" before going on to outline a specific legal framework for protecting their human rights.

The African Charter on Human and People's Rights (1981)—a regional human rights treaty for countries who are members of the African Union—stated in its preamble that the Charter sought to build on the UDHR with the "historical tradition and the values of African civilization."

Future challenges

For more than 70 years, the UDHR has been used by a wide variety of movements to help define their claims to basic human rights. Campaigners argue that to keep pace with a rapidly changing world, its scope needs to be extended. The right to a healthy environment and free internet access are just two such areas. The UDHR has achieved much, yet many millions are still denied their basic rights. ■

To mark the 70th anniversary of the UDHR, Chinese artist and activist Ai Weiwei designed a new flag, which depicts a footprint—symbolizing all those who have been forced to flee, often barefoot.

